Episode 1

The House of Mourning

ផ្ទះបុណ្យ

Game Design and Narrative Specification

Setting	Family stilt house, rural Battambang Province
Nights	Night 1 (prologue) · Night 3, 11:30 PM – dawn
Playtime	1.5 – 2 hours
Seal	#1 · The Bronze Token
Version	3.1 · October 2026 · Draft for review

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01 Episode Overview

A broken phone call pulls Sora home to Battambang for her uncle's funeral. Left alone to keep the night vigil, she learns that the family owes a debt to a land spirit, that it collects on the seventh night after Sok's death, and, in the last minutes before dawn, that the name written for the final payment is hers.

LOCATION
Battambang
Family stilt house and funeral tent

NIGHT
Night 3 of 7
Four nights remain at the end

PLAYTIME
1.5 – 2 hours
Prologue + 3 acts

CORE MECHANIC
Resource management
Kerosene, incense, matches

THREATS
Neak Ta shadow
Its shadow walks the house and the ground below

SEAL
#1 Bronze Token
Burned in a counter-ritual

1.1 Episode goal

Keep the three vigil duties, discover why Uncle Sok died, and burn the **Bronze Token**, the first seal, before 3:00 AM.

1.2 Content at a glance

Puzzles (6)	Betel offering tray · gramophone speed dial · desk drawer · three key fragments · iron-bound chest · counter-ritual
Threat encounters (4)	Incense darkness · the Neak Ta's shadow in the house · its shadow under the house · its presence behind Sora during the ritual
Optional area	The locked storage shed (oil and two lore notes)
Key choice	Share Sok's journal with Vuthy at dawn, or keep it
Revelation	Sora's name on Sok's slip of paper, beside the words "the fourth"

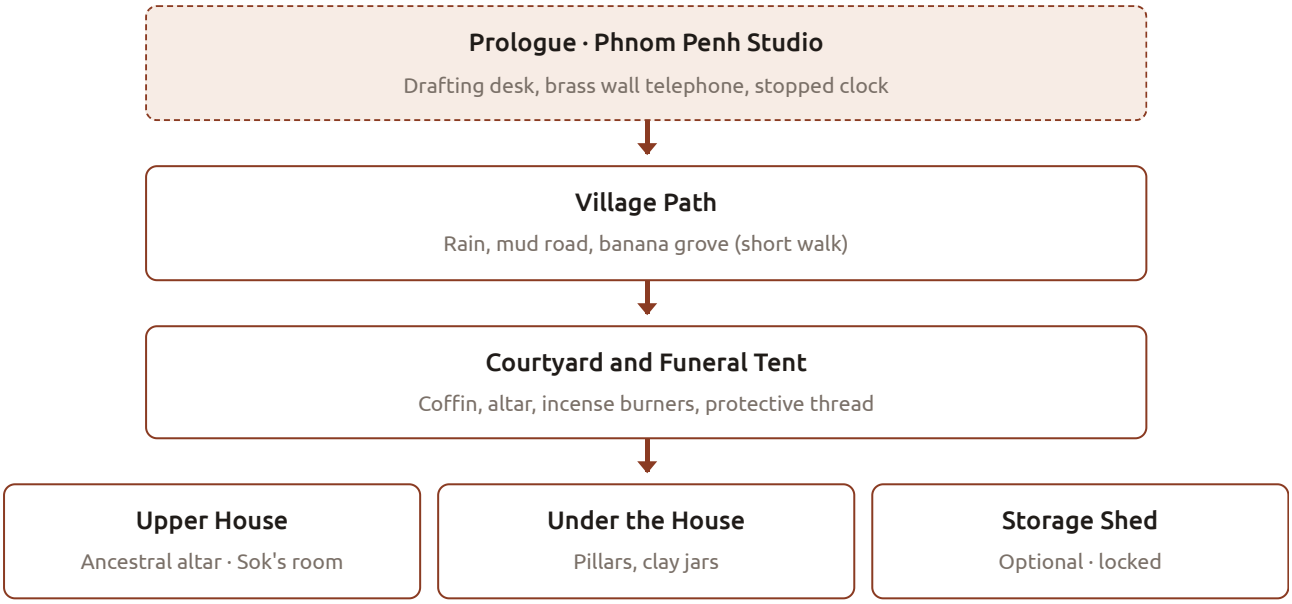
1.3 Role in the series

Introduces	Movement and interaction, satchel and sketchbook, the kerosene lamp, timed upkeep, hiding, "moves when unwatched", the first counter-ritual, the night count.
Reveals	The 1910 pact, the four payments, the seven-night deadline, and that Sok died trying to break the first seal himself.
Leads to	A line of blood on the map points to the village pagoda (Episode 2).

02 Characters

Character	Role	Description	Gameplay function
Sora ស៊ូរ៉ា 24	Protagonist	An illustrator who left the village at 12, after her mother's death, and has lived alone in Phnom Penh since her father died in 1929. Practical and sceptical of the old beliefs. Since 1929 she has stopped answering Yay Mey's letters and has missed every memorial for her mother.	Player character; seen only as hands.
Yay Mey យាយមី 66	Grandmother	Traditional, strict, deeply superstitious. Married into the family, so the debt cannot take her, but she has buried a husband and a daughter to it. She knows more than she says. Dressed in white mourning: chong kben (សំពត់ចងក្បិន) and sash (ស្បៃ).	Sets the vigil duties; teaches the betel offering.
Vuthy វុទ្ធី 26	Cousin	Sok's son, raised by his late mother's family in Battambang town. A clerk for a French trading house who manages the family's rice land and money. Polite, modern, dismissive of "village superstition", and uneasy around his father's coffin.	Introduced; leaves for town before midnight; returns at dawn for the key choice.
Uncle Sok ឪសុខ deceased	Sora's uncle	Former medic turned recluse collector of manuscripts and relics. Died on Night 1 at 8:12 PM.	His journal drives the story; his corpse and portrait are dread devices.
The Neak Ta អ្នកតា	Antagonist	A towering shadow in a distorted ancient brass mask.	Its shadow walks the upper house (Act II) and hunts beneath it (Act III); it stands behind Sora in the finale.

03 Locations and Layout



Area	Description and key props	Gameplay use
Phnom Penh Studio	A cosy third-floor apartment: drafting table, ink bottles, typography prints, green glass desk lamp, brass hand-crank telephone, wall clock that stops at 8:12 PM.	Tutorial; starting kit
Courtyard and Funeral Tent ឆាងបុណ្យ	Bamboo frame draped in wet white cotton. Raised stage with the teak coffin; Sok's portrait on a small altar with brass candle holders; four tall brass incense burners; bamboo benches, clay water jars; protective white thread tied along the frame. Hanging oil lamps and yellow wax candles.	Vigil hub; incense loop; finale
Upper House ផ្ទះឆាងជឿង	Dark teak with 1 cm gaps between floorboards and a high-gabled tiled roof. **Hall:** woven mat (កន្ទេល), ancestral altar with bronze statues and betel trays. **Sok's room:** desk, palm-leaf manuscripts (ស្លឹករឹត), brass-horn gramophone, iron-bound chest behind loose planks, wardrobes.	Betel tray; gramophone; hiding; chest
Under the House ក្រោមផ្ទះ	Dirt floor among thick pillars; firewood, ox-cart wheels, clay water jars. Pitch black.	Stealth search for key fragments
Storage Shed optional	Locked shed at the back of the yard. Key in Yay Mey's sewing box in the hall. Holds oil bottles, Chea's 1911 land deed and a photograph of Sora's mother.	Resources; two lore notes

04 Story and Gameplay by Act

Each act shows **playtime** (minutes into the episode) and **story time** (the clock in the game world).

Prologue · The Call

Playtime 0:00 – 0:10 · Night 1, 8:00 – 8:15 PM

Sora works late on an illustration during a storm. Dread grips her; ink spills across her sketchbook; a candle goes out; the clock stops at **8:12 PM**. The brass telephone rings. Through static, Yay Mey:

> *"Sora… you must come home right now… Uncle Sok… he broke it… it's inside the house—"*
>
> Yay Mey, over the telephone

A screech, shattering glass, the line goes dead. In her desk drawer lies a bundle of Yay Mey's letters, unopened, the oldest three years old; Sora shoves them into the satchel without reading them. The player learns to move, pick up and inspect, then packs the satchel, sketchbook, matchbox and hurricane lamp. A fade covers the two-day journey by train and carriage.

Act I · Arrival and the Vigil

Playtime 0:10 – 0:40 · Night 3, 11:30 PM – 1:00 AM

NARRATIVE

The carriage driver refuses the flooded road, so Sora walks the last stretch by lamplight. In the courtyard, under the white funeral tent, Yay Mey greets her in tears, then, quietly: "You did not come for your mother's memorial. Three years, Sora." **Vuthy** is there too, in a town suit, stiff and polite. He calls the rituals "superstition", tells Sora their grandmother is not well, and leaves for town before midnight, promising to return at dawn.

Exhausted after two days of mourning, Yay Mey gives Sora the three vigil duties: keep the lamp burning, keep the four corner incense sticks alight, and keep the protective thread around the tent unbroken. Before resting, she asks Sora to prepare a proper **betel offering** for the ancestral altar, "as your mother used to".

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Vigil duties	Lamp oil drains; incense burns down every 10–12 minutes; the thread can be inspected.
Betel offering tray new	Arrange the offering correctly (section 6.1). Reward: matches blessed at the altar, the **sanctified matches** needed for the final ritual.
Optional: storage shed	Find the key in Yay Mey's sewing box. Spare oil and two lore notes.

Act II · The Unbroken Taboo

Playtime 0:40 – 1:15 · Night 3, 1:00 – 2:00 AM

NARRATIVE

At **1:00 AM** a cold gust blows out the tent's lamps. Wet footsteps cross the floorboards above. In Sok's room, behind a loose plank, Sora finds pages of his journal addressed *"to whoever keeps my vigil"*. They describe Great-grandfather Chea's pact of 1910, the four payments and the five seals. Then the gramophone beside the desk begins to turn by itself, and once its speed is corrected, Sok's own recorded voice fills the room:

> *"On the seventh night after my death it will come to collect what is owed. Break the seals before then. I tried to begin. If you are hearing this, I failed."*
>
> Uncle Sok, on a gramophone record

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Gramophone	Plays a funeral chant backwards on its own; fix the speed to hear Sok's recorded warning and where the desk-drawer key is hidden (section 6.2).
The shadow in the hallway	The Neak Ta's shadow walks the house; dragging footsteps approach. Put out the lamp and hide behind a wardrobe until the shadow passes.
The portrait	Downstairs, all four incense sticks are ash, and in the portrait Sok's eyes are open, staring at Sora.

Act III · The First Seal

Playtime 1:15 – 1:50 · Night 3, 2:00 – 3:00 AM

NARRATIVE

The protective thread snaps. Lamps die one by one. In the coffin, Sok's body shifts whenever Sora looks away. The journal says the first seal, the Bronze Token, is in the iron-bound chest, and its key was broken into three pieces and hidden under the house.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Under-house search	Collect three brass key fragments from clay jars while the Neak Ta's shadow hunts beneath the house by sound and light.
The chest	Assemble the key; open the chest: the Bronze Token, a map with four faint marks, and a folded slip of paper Sora pockets without reading.

Element	Description
Counter-ritual	Place the token in the main incense burner and light it with the sanctified matches while the mantra is recited. The presence stands behind Sora, its shadow huge on the tent cloth. She must not turn around.

Resolution · The Fourth Name

Night 3, 3:00 AM – dawn

The token burns; wind tears through the tent; the screech fades. In the grey light before dawn, Sok's body lies still. Vuthy returns from town and asks what happened and what his father left. **Key choice:** show him the journal, or keep it (section 7).

Alone again, Sora unfolds the slip from the chest. In Sok's hand: a list of four names, three crossed out: *Chea, Chhun, Kanha.* The fourth line has been scraped and rewritten. It reads **Sora**.

Blood seeps across her map, darkening the first faint mark: the village pagoda. In the sketchbook, she draws seven circles and fills in three. **Four nights remain.**

05 Threat Escalation

Act	Threat	What changes
I	Darkness and whispers	No direct danger. Letting the incense die darkens the tent and brings louder whispers: a warning, not a punishment.
II	The Neak Ta's shadow, in the house	Hunts by sound only. Hiding with the lamp off is always safe.
III	The Neak Ta's shadow, beneath the house	Hunts by sound *and* is drawn to lamplight; the lamps around the yard are dying, so darkness is now both safety and danger. The corpse moves when unwatched.
Finale	The presence behind Sora	Turning around fails the ritual and restarts it from its checkpoint.

06 Puzzles

6.1 The betel offering tray new

A short cultural puzzle that teaches the player to look carefully, and that the household's rituals matter.

Step	Action	Result
1	Listen to Yay Mey's instruction and look at the old drawing of the tray pinned near the altar. It is Kanha's, and Sora recognises her own hand in her mother's lines.	Sketch of the correct layout added to the sketchbook.
2	Gather betel leaves, areca nut, lime paste, a candle and incense from around the house.	Items in the satchel.
3	Arrange them on the tray as in the drawing and place it on the altar.	Yay Mey blesses a set of matches: the sanctified matches.

A wrong arrangement can be corrected freely, but each wrong placement records a small respect penalty. The exact layout must be confirmed with the cultural advisor.

6.2 The gramophone and desk

Step	Action	Result
1	The gramophone starts a reversed chant by itself.	Draws the player in.
2	Turn the governor speed dial until the audio becomes clear speech.	Sok's recorded voice delivers his warning and names the hiding place of the drawer key.
3	Retrieve the key; open the desk drawer.	The rest of the journal, including the chest's location.

6.3 The key and the chest

Step	Action	Result
1	Search the clay jars under the house while avoiding the shadow.	Three brass fragments.
2	Combine the fragments in the satchel.	Complete key.
3	Remove the loose planks in Sok's room; unlock the chest.	Bronze Token, map, folded slip.

6.4 The counter-ritual

Step	Action	Result
1	Bring the token to the coffin altar before 3:00 AM.	Checkpoint saved.
2	Place it in the main incense burner.	The presence appears behind Sora.

Step	Action	Result
3	Light it with the sanctified matches without turning around.	Seal #1 breaks.

07 Key Choice and Tracking

SHARE THE JOURNAL

Sora shows Vuthy his father's journal. He reads it in silence, then says he has to think. **Vuthy +1.** In Episode 3 he already knows what the seals are, which makes his later actions a deliberate choice rather than ignorance.

KEEP THE JOURNAL

Sora says only that his father left old papers. Vuthy nods and doesn't push. **No change.** He learns the truth on his own later, and resents being kept out.

Tracked in this episode	Source
Respect	Betel tray correct on the first try (+1); incense never allowed to burn out through neglect (+1; the scripted ash in Act II does not count)
Knowledge (lore notes)	5 notes: three journal pages beyond the required ones, the 1911 land deed and Kanha's photograph (shed)
Vuthy	Journal shared at dawn

08 Mechanics Reference

Values marked *target* are starting points for playtesting.

Mechanic	Rules	Feedback
Kerosene lamp	Burns continuously while lit; a full tank lasts about 12 minutes (*target*). Turn it off to save oil or to hide.	Glass gauge on the lamp; sputtering flame.
Matches	Limited. Ordinary matches relight lamps and incense; the sanctified matches are reserved for the ritual.	Count shown when the matchbox is opened.
Incense loop	Corner sticks burn down every 10–12 minutes; fresh sticks come from the house altar.	Stick length, thinning smoke, whispers.
Hiding	In a hiding spot with the lamp off, Sora is undetectable unless touched.	Muffled sound, heartbeat.
Watched / unwatched	The corpse moves only when out of view.	Changed position when the player looks back.
Being caught	Short scare, fade, restart at the last checkpoint; no health bar.	A page torn from the sketchbook.
Night count	The sketchbook shows seven circles; one fills at the end of each episode.	Sketchbook page.

09 Items and Lore Notes

Item	Type	Found / use
Satchel, sketchbook, hurricane lamp, matchbox	Equipment	Studio
Oil bottles, incense sticks	Consumable	House, grounds, shed
Betel leaves, areca nut, lime, candle	Puzzle items	Kitchen and hall
Sanctified matches	Key item	Reward for the betel tray
Desk-drawer key, brass key fragments ×3	Key items	Gramophone clue; clay jars
Bronze Token	Seal #1	Chest; burned in the ritual. A fragment survives as the Episode 5 remnant.
Map with four faint marks	Story item	Chest; each mark is revealed by a blood trail
Sok's slip of names	Story item	Chest; read at dawn
Lore notes ×5	Optional	Journal pages, land deed (1911), Kanha's photograph

10 Audio and Visual Specification

Colour palette	Sepia, dark mahogany, amber flame, cold off-white linen, wet mud grey.
Post-processing	1930s film grain, chromatic aberration, vignette, dynamic shadows.
Light sources	Hurricane lamp, hanging oil lamps, wax candles, moonlight, lightning.
Ambience	Heavy rain, thunder, cicadas, bullfrogs, creaking teak.
Horror cues	Backward gramophone chant, clock chimes, snapping thread, dragging footsteps, telephone static, whispers.
Music	Sparse, Pinpeat-inspired (ពិណពាទ្យ); mostly silence.
Interface	100% diegetic: oil gauge on the lamp; inventory, map and night count in the sketchbook.

11 Glossary

Term	Khmer	Meaning	Note
Boon Sop	បុណ្យសព	Funeral ceremony	Series title
Neak Ta	អ្នកតា	Guardian spirit of the land	
Funeral tent	ឧោងបុណ្យ	Ceremonial pavilion	Confirm preferred term
Phteah Rong Doeung	ផ្ទះឧោងដើង	Traditional gabled house	
Krom Phteah	ក្រោមផ្ទះ	Space under a stilt house	
Kanteal	កន្ទេល	Woven mat	
Sleok Rith	ស្លឹករឹត	Palm-leaf manuscript	
Chong Kben / Sbai	សំពត់ចងក្បិន / សៃ្ប	Wrapped trousers / sash	
Coffin	មឈូស	Coffin	Replaces v1 "Mneang Sop"
Clay jar	ពាង	Large water jar	Replaces v1 "Pheon"
Oil lamp	ចង្កៀង	Lamp	Replaces v1 "Chhenglang"
Betel	ស្លា / ម្លូ	Areca nut / betel leaf	Confirm
Protective thread	—	White cotton thread	Confirm the Khmer term (v1 used the Thai "sai sin")

All Khmer spellings, including the names Chea, Chhun, Kanha and Vuthy, must be confirmed by a native speaker.

12 Revision Notes and Open Issues

Changes in v3.0

- Playtime reduced to 1.5–2 hours; the journey is a fade; the act structure is tighter.
- New: Vuthy, the betel offering puzzle (which supplies the sanctified matches), the seven-night deadline, threat escalation, the optional storage shed, the dawn key choice and the "fourth name" revelation.
- Sok now dies trying to burn the first seal himself, which explains Yay Mey's "he broke it".
- The Bronze Token is in the chest (the shed is now an optional area); the map shows faint marks revealed one by one.
- **v3.1** (Story Bible): Sora's flaw (the unopened letters, Yay Mey's reproach); Kanha as the artist of the betel drawing; Sok's warning now heard on the gramophone rather than read.
- **v3.2**: the hallway walker and under-house roamer are now explicitly the Neak Ta's shadow (Story Bible rule 16).

Open issues

CONFIRM WITH THE CULTURAL ADVISOR

- The correct contents and layout of a household betel offering, and who would bless the matches.
- Customs for the night vigil and for the seventh-day funeral rites.
- Khmer spellings of all names and terms in the glossary.